



motivations? What is driving their desire to achieve? Are they doing this because they feel they have to, or is there a deeper reason behind starting the training programme?

Understanding this is crucial for designing a programme that is effective and tailored to the athletes' needs.

HOW?

How will you implement the programme, and how will the athletes manage it on a day-to-day basis? Will your approach be hands-on or hands-off? How will you deliver the programme — physically, digitally, or on paper? How will you log and track their progress?

LENGTH

What is the duration of the programme? This will be influenced by many factors, but deciding on an initial timeline will provide a target for the athletes to aim for.

COMPETITION

Will there be competition throughout the programme, or is it structured in a phased manner? Do you need to prepare for these

competitions in a periodised manner? Or is this an off-season opportunity to focus solely on preparation without worrying about performance deadlines?

GOALS

What do the athletes want to achieve from the programme? Are these goals grounded in reality or fantasy? It's easy to say, "I want my 20m sprint time to be X" or "My reactive strength should be Y." But do they truly understand the effort and energy required to achieve those goals? This is where reality and false promises are revealed for both the athletes and the coach. It's essential to ask these questions to ensure realistic goal-setting for the athletes.

TESTING

How will you measure the progress and success of the intervention? Deciding on an appropriate battery of tests is important to ensure you are implementing effective changes for the athletes. Testing will also allow you to make adjustments as needed to stay focused on the goals. It's wise

Test to be the best: Deciding on an appropriate battery of tests is important to ensure coaches are implementing effective changes for the athlete. Testing will also allow them to make adjustments as needed to stay focused on the goals. GETTY IMAGES

to have one or two solid tests, along with a few additional tests that can help assess other fitness domains. Time and equipment availability will always be factors, so tests don't need to be overly flamboyant — they just need to measure what you are trying to change.

Concluding thoughts

By breaking down the issues into specific components and working from a first-principles perspective, you have a prospective shot at success.

Programmes and interventions can make significant changes by leveraging the information you gather from the areas above, increasing the likelihood of achieving desired success.